Movie Studios Promote Films by Just Giving Away Money

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Promoting a movie in the internet age usually means **memes**, **influencer** screenings and wild popcorn buckets. But two studios have tried a simpler trick: just dangling money in front of people.

The marketing teams behind "How to Rob a Bank," from Amazon MGM Studios, and "Ebenezer," from Paramount Pictures, both used cash giveaways ahead of their shared November 13 release in North American theaters.

For the **heist** thriller "How to Rob a Bank," a branded ATM was moved between movie theaters around Los Angeles over four days. Fans who followed the film's social media channels could find clues to the machine's location and a PIN number, which would trigger a **payout** of a single one-hundred-dollar bill.

"Ebenezer" took a cheekier approach. The studio promoted an official Venmo account for its main character, the famously penny-pinching Ebenezer Scrooge from Charles Dickens's classic tale. Users could request money from the account and those who scrolled through its transactions found it shared Scrooge's spirit: the only completed **payouts** were single cents.

The Venmo account was only active for a few hours, though Paramount teased followers to "check back," saying "Ebenezer might be feeling generous on Venmo again."

Both stunts fit their films' themes: "Ebenezer" is about a **miser** who catches the Christmas spirit, while "How to Rob a Bank" follows thieves who teach subscribers how to take money back from banks.

There was also an unexpected twist: the Venmo account could receive payments from users, not just send them. One fan, Krystyna Ursta of Los Angeles, said she sent about $30 and received a full refund a few days later plus an extra penny and an invitation to a special screening in New York. A person familiar with the account said all money received was sent back privately.

Word Treasure

heist -- A planned robbery, often of a bank, usually shown as clever and daring in films.

payout -- Money that is paid out to someone, for example from a machine or as a prize.

miser -- A person who hates spending money and keeps as much of it as possible.

influencer -- A person with many online followers whom companies pay to promote things.

memes -- Funny images, videos or phrases that spread quickly from person to person online.

Background you need

Movie studios promote new films to build excitement before opening day, and unusual stunts are a way to get people sharing the story online.

A heist film tells a story about a planned robbery, so a cash-machine stunt matches its theme.

"Ebenezer" draws on Charles Dickens's classic tale of Ebenezer Scrooge, a miser who learns generosity at Christmas -- which is why sending people single cents fits the joke.

Break it down

LEAD: Two studios promote their November 13 films with cash giveaways

KEY EVENT: A roving $100 ATM for 'How to Rob a Bank' and a penny-paying Scrooge Venmo account for 'Ebenezer'

+- WHO: Amazon MGM Studios and Paramount Pictures marketing teams, and fans in Los Angeles

+- TWIST: The Venmo account could also receive money, and one fan's $30 was fully refunded with a bonus penny

OPEN QUESTION: Whether 'Ebenezer' will feel generous on Venmo again

Why it matters

Stunts like these show how hard companies compete for attention online -- and why fans should read the fine print before sending money to a promotion.

Test what you remember

1. What simple trick did two studios use to promote their films?

- (A) Renaming the films
- (B) Hiding the trailers
- (C) Giving away money
- (D) Free popcorn forever

2. What could fans get from the 'How to Rob a Bank' ATM?

- (A) A car
- (B) A movie role
- (C) A single one-hundred-dollar bill
- (D) Free tickets for a year

3. How did fans find the ATM?

- (A) By asking a bank
- (B) A newspaper map
- (C) It stayed in one theater all month
- (D) Clues on the film's social media channels

4. What did Scrooge's Venmo account actually pay out?

- (A) Movie tickets
- (B) Single cents
- (C) Gold coins
- (D) Hundred-dollar bills

5. When do both films open in North American theaters?

- (A) December 25
- (B) Next summer
- (C) They have already closed
- (D) November 13

6. What happened to the fan who sent the account about $30?

- (A) She got a full refund, plus an extra penny and an invitation to a special screening
- (B) She lost the money
- (C) She was ignored
- (D) She won the ATM

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: D 4: B 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Paramount, teasing followers: Hinted that 'Ebenezer might be feeling generous on Venmo again' and told fans to check back.

2. A person familiar with the account: Said all money the account received was sent back privately.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):